

Then you had to get educated. More cost. So beyond the love you created in the hearts of your parents and the people around you who adored you, you didn't have any real value in the market until you became a consumer yourself.

But first, you had to go to college. So the Bank lent you a small fortune, and you were grateful for every dime. Then you got your first job. Your parents were so proud of you, and so was the Bank. They started to send you credit card notices with low introductory interest rates, and you signed up for one. Then the Bank helped you open up your first checking account so your paycheck could be automatically deposited. They weren't too interested in what you saved, hence they paid almost no interest. After that, they sold you on some mutual funds or a money market fund that also had you automatically depositing a small sum every month. All of these accounts came with fees. But you paid them, because you were trying to do the right thing with your money.

Then came your mortgage, the biggest sum of money you ever borrowed and a huge source of income to the Bank. This was the Big Kahuna, the one service the Bank had been waiting to sell you ever since you were a beautiful little baby. Most people take out a mortgage with the bank at which they first opened a savings or checking account, and that's just what you did, too. Why? The Bank knew you, and you trusted the Bank. You'd been such a good customer so far, always making those minimum payments on your credit card, never missing a student loan payment, so the Bank gave you a pretty good rate.

But here is where the "Game of Life" begins, my dear child. At first you needed the Bank's money. You needed the student loan and the credit card and the mortgage. That's how we get ahead in life and become self-sufficient. But to win this numbers game, you have to be as ruthless as the Bank. Problem is, the Bank sets the terms of the mortgage and the level of interest you pay on your credit cards.

Getting to a place where the Bank is paying you more interest than you're paying out is the essence of growing wealth and winning the numbers game. You have to begin to tip the balance in your favor as soon as possible. But it's a relationship. Understand that there are